unleash a burst of fire on the search party. I would go around from time to time to ensure that protocols were being followed. Each search party was accompanied by one or two of the village elders as a precaution against any allegations being raised later of any wrongdoing by the search party, usually of theft. These elders would be the ones to sign the clearance certificate on the termination of the search.

About mid-day, there was a sudden murmur in the crowd. One of the search parties was nearing a particular house when the village elder accompanying them hesitated and said something that was picked up by the assembled villagers. That somehow spread to the other mohallas too and all of a sudden, the folk who had been sitting peacefully and resigned to this search grew agitated. We guessed that we were probably close to some terrorist hideout and this was a diversionary tactic. As the search progressed, the unrest increased. Some of the OGWs, terrorist sympathizers in the crowd, egged on the villagers, who started throwing stones and tried to break the cordon. The search was temporarily halted as we tried to pacify the crowd, who were shouting slogans with the women ululating in shrill, unnerving tones. Some of the bolder young people tried to storm forward and snatch our weapons. When that happened, we had no option but to open fire, first in the air and then on the miscreants themselves for our own safety and security. I sensed the situation was getting out of hand and decided to call off the operation. The search parties who were inside the village disengaged first, supported by the cordon party. Once at a safe distance, the cordon also disengaged. When the villagers saw that we were disengaging, they did not attempt to follow us, but we left behind six dead and an equal number of wounded villagers, not all of them blameless. Not a good operation at all. Some may even call it a botched operation.

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation